

THE SKY LINE

Prefabricated Blight

THERE is now, within the city limits, a good handful of housing projects in various stages of completion. Since the housing shortage is what it is, any truly critical appraisal of these undertakings will have to come, I am afraid, from a non-tenant. Those who are lucky enough to be accepted by the landlords will probably view their new homes through a rosy haze, as a Displaced Person might view Ellis Island. Yet almost all these projects are solemn reminders of how different the postwar world is from what most people hoped it would be.

Perhaps the greatest and grimmest of these housing developments is Stuyvesant Town, the massive palisade of apartments being erected by the Metropolitan Life Insurance Company between Fourteenth and Twentieth Streets, in the area bounded on the east by Avenue C and a small stretch of the Franklin D. Roosevelt Drive, and on the west by First Avenue. By the time this group of buildings is finished, twenty-four thousand people will be living on its sixty-one acres. (The original street and block pattern of New York was planned for a density of from seventy to ninety people an acre; this new development will have a density of three hundred and ninety-three.) That makes this community larger than sixteen thousand other towns in the United States and smaller than only four hundred. Instead of lowering the density in the area, the proprietors of Stuyvesant Town, abetted by the City of New York, have established a pattern of greater congestion. If New York were completely rebuilt in this fashion, even Mr. Robert Moses, who has had a lot to do with setting this pattern in housing, would perhaps cry "Uncle!"

When I first inspected Stuyvesant Town, a year ago, the development seemed to me an unrelieved nightmare. Though the buildings are not a continuous unit, they present to the beholder an unbroken façade of brick, thirteen stories high, absolutely uniform in every detail, mechanically conceived and mechanically executed, with the word "control" implicit in every aspect of the design. This, I said to myself, is the architecture of the Police State, embodying all the vices of regimentation one associates with state control at its unimaginative worst. But the entrepreneurs of this enterprise are not commis-

sars; they are the president and directors of a great life-insurance company, and they have performed this feat of regimentation in the name of free enterprise and individual initiative. To encourage the exercise of these virtues and to coax private capital into this large-scale housing effort, the City of New York aided in the acquisition of the land and allowed the new owners to wipe out the existing network of streets, which occupied over twenty per cent of the area, without exacting any payment for the additional land thus acquired, although two small strips, along First Avenue and Twentieth Street, were ceded to the municipality so that it could widen these thoroughfares.

In order to make the Metropolitan's control over this feudal domain absolute and inviolable, a public school and two parochial schools in the territory were also demolished. Now no citizen of New York may set foot within Stuyvesant Town except by permission of the owners, and a private police force is on duty to exercise, if the proprietors require it, this control. And that is not all. Principally, I believe, at the urging of Mr. Moses, as City Construction Coördinator, the city has consented to waive all taxes on the improvements for twenty-five years—amounting to an estimated fifty-three million dollars—to insure housing at seventeen dollars a room per month.

There is no provision in the agreement between municipality and owners to provide housing for the people driven from their homes by the clearing of the land, nor is there a provision that only low-income groups shall have the benefit of this very generous subsidy. Naturally, the Metropolitan Life, like any other prudent landlord, is selecting its tenants on the basis of "desirability," from a group of people who, though mostly veterans, are a fair distance from the ragged economic edge; the construction of six large underground garages for them is evidence enough of that. Only in the Looking-Glass World of Lewis Carroll does any of this make sense.

A YEAR has passed since I saw the first units of Stuyvesant Town, but after a second inspection I find that my nightmarish impression of the project has not dissolved. As things go nowa-



ARPEGE



RUMEUR



PRETEXTE



SCANDAL



MY SIN

the best

Paris

has to offer



LANVIN

ALL LANVIN PERFUMES ARE IMPORTED FROM FRANCE



UNIVERSAL GENÈVE

Good Watchmaking
is inherent in this
new group of
conservative styles
for women
by Universal Genève.
In white or yellow
14 kt. gold, \$71.50,
Federal Tax Included.
At Leading Jewelers

THE HENRI STERN WATCH AGENCY, INC., 507 Fifth Ave., N. Y. 17

days, one has only a choice of nightmares. Shall it be the old, careless urban nightmare of post-Civil War New York, planned so that from a third to a half of the interior space of each house and apartment is dark, airless, dismal, so that there is no view worth speaking of from the windows, except by accident, and so that there is a maximum amount of noise from the streets? Or shall it be the new nightmare, of a great super-block, quiet, orderly, self-contained, but designed as if the fabulous innkeeper Procrustes had turned architect—a nightmare not of caprice and self-centered individualism but of impersonal regimentation, apparently for people who have no identity but the serial numbers of their Social Security cards? Since I doubt that the directors of the Metropolitan Life Insurance Company really wished to produce this effect, it might be interesting to see how it all came about.

Let's look first at the over-all plan of Stuyvesant Town. To understand that plan, one must visualize the basic unit—an elevator apartment house in the shape of a cross, with four wings of equal dimensions. There are four such units on First Avenue, and three others on Avenue C. But mostly two, three, or four units are joined together into rows, in which there are occasional variations, to round a corner of the site. These rows form, roughly, a series of open quadrangles around the perimeter of the super-block. (Local traffic moves within this area along curving drive-ways, and curving walks provide pedestrian access. The space wasted by streets in the typical old city plan is here fortunately converted into playgrounds and open space.) The rest of the units, eight in number, form the spokes of an imaginary oval wheel, splaying out from a large green, called Stuyvesant Oval, at the center of the plot. This oval is planted with big oaks and surrounded by a triple row of plane trees, all of mature growth. Except for a few skyscraper apartments, which temporarily have uninterrupted views from their upper stories, nowhere in the more expensive residential districts in Manhattan will you discover any comparable access to sunlight, air, and vista. Nowhere else, either, have the differences in level at various parts of the site served better for handsome plantings of rhododendron, with dark ivy ground cover to contrast with patches of greensward.

Superficially, all this seems like a positive gain, but it will not bear close examination, for neither functionally nor visually have the planners made the most of their site. Far less land in

"and what did Walter Winchell say?" "'bravorchids!'"

New Stages, Inc. presents
"The Respectful Prostitute"
Cort Theatre

(Advertisement)

The Wedgwood Room



AT SUPPER
**PETER
LIND
HAYES** and
MARY HEALY

DINNER & SUPPER
**EDDY
DUCHIN**
and his Orchestra



**MISCHA
BORR**
and his
Orchestra

alternating at Supper
Cover from 10:30, \$2



The Waldorf Astoria

Park Avenue at 50th Street

Fabulous Fancy

Gay Parisian creators have translated their whimsy into the lasting laughter of the clown and scarecrow. The captivating clown with body and hat of rubies and gold, diamond face... \$1075.* The scarecrow, body and hat of rubies and gold, ruby face... \$1000.* Either in cultured pearls from \$350.*



VAN CLEEF & ARPELS

World famous designers of precious jewelry

744 FIFTH AVENUE, NEW YORK • PARIS • LONDON • PALM BEACH

*Prices subject to Fed. Tax

Pat. Pend.

the area is now occupied by streets, but, on the other hand, all the major open spaces except Stuyvesant Oval are given over to completely asphalted playgrounds, surrounded by spiky iron fences and paved walks, that offer none of the natural resources or the implements for any kind of play except the most mechanical and organized. The needs of different age groups are provided for only by differences in the type of playground equipment. Since most of the families in Stuyvesant Town belong to young veterans and the small fry are almost all under five, the woodenness of the scheme is not yet fully apparent, but once time produces the normal variety of children, from toddlers to adolescents, this failure will become glaring, and the alternative to conflict and frustration will be more regimentation. However they are labelled, the open spaces in this development, it is evident, were not designed specifically at the beginning, as they should have been, for special uses. There should be hedges and windscreens for mothers and infants, digging pits and water pools for the toddlers, and trees and bushes for hide-and-seek and provision for games of make-believe for still older children, and each space should show, by its size and shape, the function it aims to serve. No, these playground spaces are merely leftovers, bleak asphalt wastes, marks of that absence of human interest, of that almost positive distaste for beauty, which characterize this project. Not merely the human scale but human-heartedness is lacking.

If you did not know what the ultimate population of Stuyvesant Town would be, you might think that the provision of open spaces is exceedingly generous, but when the density of population is taken into account, it is plain that what has been allotted does not meet even the most meagre requirements of good planning. City planners everywhere are agreed that one acre of open green space to every hundred people is desirable and that one acre for every three hundred people is the barest minimum standard for health and decency. On this minimum basis, the population of Stuyvesant Town would require, apart from the normal space between buildings, some eighty acres of open land, which is nineteen more than are taken up by the entire project. So, instead of easing the general deficiency of parks and playgrounds in Manhattan—in return for the city's munificent subsidy—Stuyvesant Town actually adds to this chronic shortage.

Visually, the case against this devel-



**You Pay a
Great Compliment
When You Serve**

Great Western
EXTRA DRY
American Champagne

MADE AND BOTTLED BY
PLEASANT VALLEY WINE CO. RHEIMS, N.Y.
CONTENTS 4 1/2 QUARTS

Great Western
AMERICAN CHAMPAGNES

**ONE OF THE WORLD'S
GREAT CHAMPAGNES**

THE PLEASANT VALLEY WINE CO.
RHEIMS, HAMMONDSPORT, N. Y.

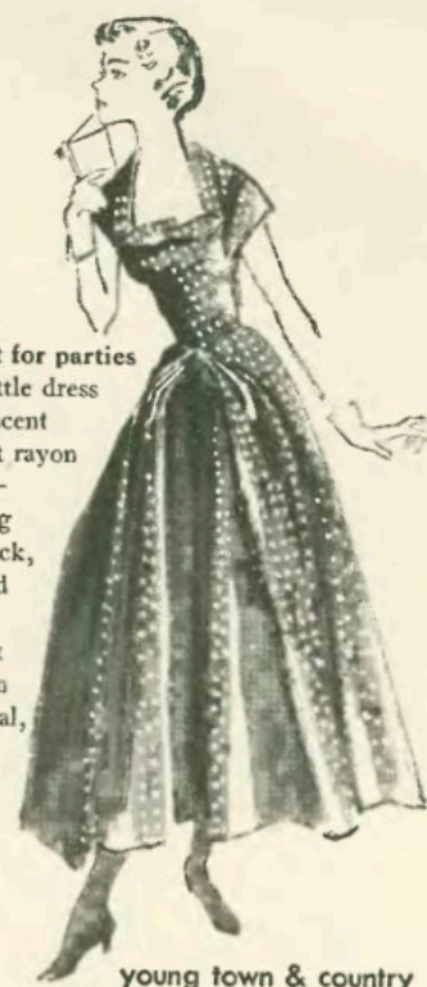
MAKERS OF FINE WINES
FOR NEARLY 100 YEARS

opment is just as strong. By the exercise of extraordinary ingenuity, the landlord's Board of Design—let its members remain anonymous—contrived to accentuate the stereotyped character of these buildings by so placing them that one cannot anywhere find a vista that is not quickly blocked by thirteen stories of brick and glass. Once you are inside the super-block, you are walled in. Perhaps the planners had in mind a precept of Camillo Sitte, the great Austrian theorist of romantic planning, who remarked how much more pleasant it is to have a gable or a tower greet the eye at the end of a street than the dull fade-away of an endless vista, but, lacking any variation in roof line or silhouette, any sudden peek at river or sky, what meets the eye within Stuyvesant Town merely accents the prisonlike character of the architecture. Even the pool of quiet green at the center of the development—the happiest part of the whole plan—loses a good part of its repose through the inhuman scale of the architecture.

One must not blame the architects and planners too severely. Once the decision was made to house twenty-four thousand people on a site that should not be made to hold more than six thousand, all the other faults followed almost automatically. For this community of twenty-four thousand inhabitants will not have, within its walls, a school or a library, a church or a community room, a motion-picture theatre or an auditorium, a clinic, a lying-in home, or a hospital, or any of the other essential facilities for its population. Because of the variety of function of such buildings, there would have been an opportunity for fresh form, too, and this, in turn, might have had a humanizing effect upon the whole design. Considering all the benefits it might have derived from beginning at scratch, on a site as large as this, Stuyvesant Town is a caricature of urban rebuilding.

I HAVE reserved my most favorable comment to the last, and at that it must be qualified. The standards of interior space throughout the project are generous; even the minimum accommodations are more spacious than is usual in prewar public housing projects of the same order, and the kitchens, one side of which is so short that they are almost triangular in shape, are marvellously convenient just because of this fact. The living rooms, all twelve by eighteen feet, are more than adequate by New York standards. I would be more enthusiastic about the quality of this liv-

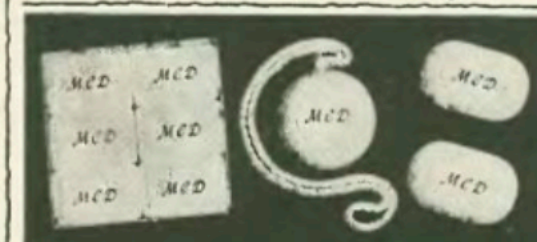
Perfect for parties
Crisp little dress
of iridescent
coin-dot rayon
taffeta—
flattering
cowl neck,
moulded
bodice,
bouffant
skirt. In
gunmetal,
9 to 15
\$29.95



young town & country

B. Weinstein

7 east 57 street, new york



**Superb French-milled
Monogrammed Soaps**

Smart, welcome gifts. 3 sizes, lettered to order with monogram that lasts life of soap. Hand cakes in white with lavender or jasmine scent; pink with jasmine; green with pine; yellow with lemon verbena; tan with carnation. 6 cakes \$3. Shower cake (with cord), grand for man. Tan with carnation scent; white with jasmine. \$2.50 each. Same 2 colors, scents in giant bath cakes, 2 for \$3. Add 25c box postage. Booklet free.

Katherine Gray C LAZY U RANCH
Box NY
Granby, Colorado



"Forget-Me-Not"
Child's Set
in Sterling
with blue
enamel flowers.
Curved spoons.
Write for
Gift Folder.

Select your favorite combination, gift-wrapped in bags. For the newborn baby, Spoon \$5.00, Pusher \$6.00. For the older child, Spoon \$8.50, Knife \$9.50, Fork \$8.50. The entire set, boxed as shown: \$49.50. Federal Tax included. Available only at

H. NILS HANDWROUGHT
DANISH SILVER
1 East 58th St., New York City. At the Savoy-Plaza.

ing space if the eighteen-foot dimension were window frontage instead of depth. And about a hundred and twenty square feet of costly space is wasted in each apartment on a windowless anteroom, called the foyer, plus the unusable dark end of the living room. This may be low-rental "economy," but only in Alice's Looking-Glass World.

FROM this sad Stuyvesant Town story of prefabricated blight, I turn with relief to Peter Cooper Village, the project's northern neighbor, also a Metropolitan Life venture. Its buildings are two stories taller, but the effect is not so tight and closed-in; the rooms are larger; and, though the rental is quite moderate compared with anything being offered in other sections of Manhattan, the citizens of New York have not underwritten this moderation by subsidies derived from their taxes. The great structures of Peter Cooper Village are set at an angle to First Avenue, and, if one stands on the corner of Twenty-first Street, the succession of high units seems to form a series of receding steps, like a Cubist demonstration of the relation of color and tone to distance—almost the only effect that can be called aesthetic or architectural in either project. Photographers will probably be taking pictures of that particular view for a dozen years. Peter Cooper Village is, aesthetically at least, a little less prisonlike than Stuyvesant Town. But neither form of congestion should be allowed to become a standard for urban redevelopment. —LEWIS MUMFORD

At 11 a.m., Ely pulls a pair of trousers on over his pajama tops, puts on socks and slippers, and begins work, dictating to three secretaries in relays.—Redbook.

All three of them in stitches, we have no doubt.

STOCKHOLM, Sept. 28 (AP)—Keeping up a royal tradition, Sweden's 90-year-old King Gustaf V went hunting yesterday at Hunneberg in Western Sweden. After 10 hours on the beat, the King had two elfs to his credit.—Indianapolis News.

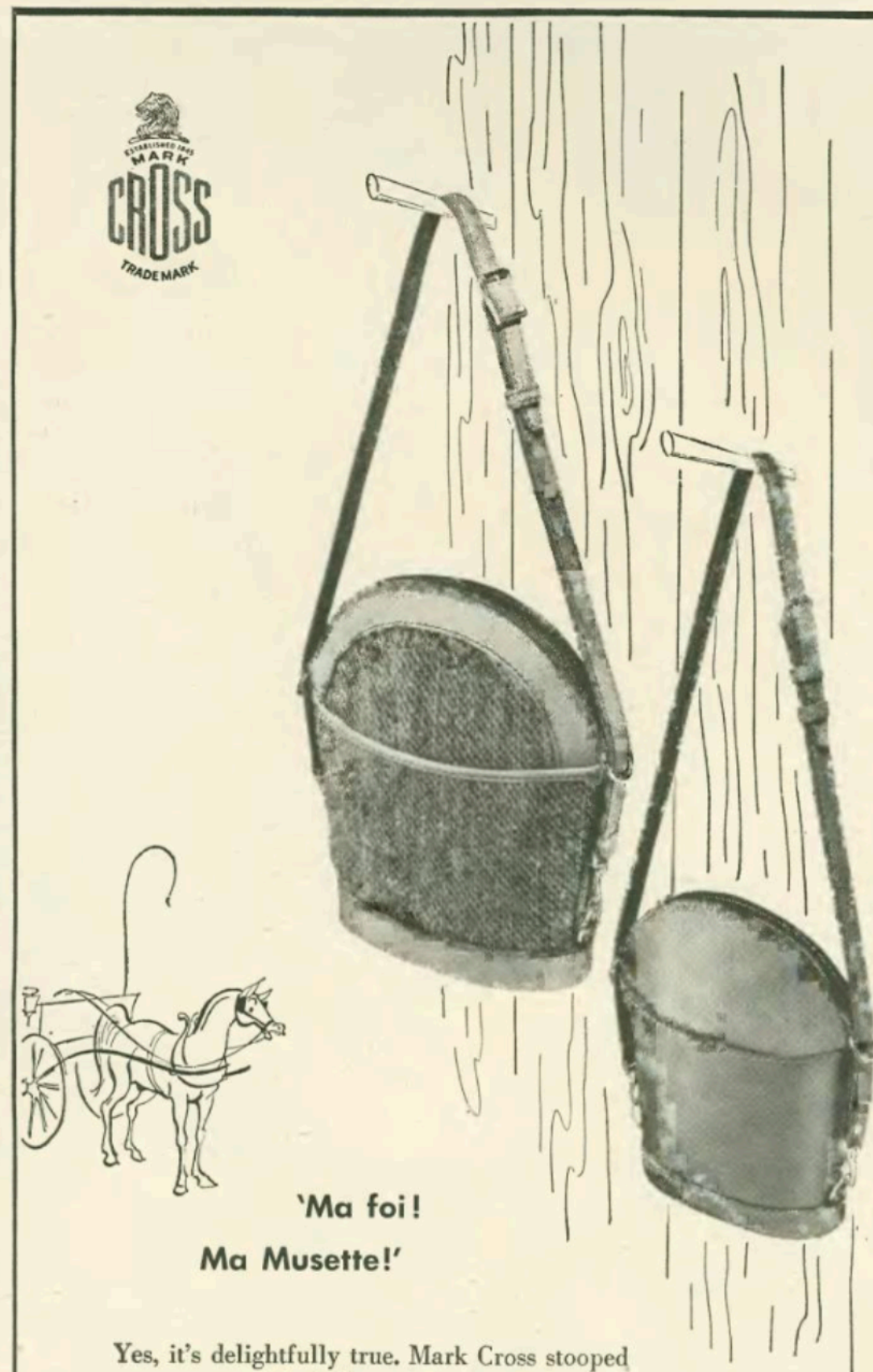
Elves, please.

THE GOOD OLD DAYS

[From an adv. in Vogue,
November 15, 1924]

CAN YOUR DAUGHTER SUPERVISE SERVANTS?

If she marries well, she will have to organize and manage a corps of five to fifteen servants. Does she know what each should do? And how it should be done?



**'Ma foi!
Ma Musette!'**

Yes, it's delightfully true. Mark Cross stooped to lift the humble musette (nose-bag to you) dangling from beneath the Paris fiacre, and copied it faithfully, if a trifle luxuriously, to make the smartest, most original arm and/or shoulder bag of the season. In handsome hand-loomed tweeds with saddler's leather accents. Or solid polished hide in amber, green, golden, russet, black and red. A Mark Cross exclusive, 9½" high, \$28.50*; 11½" high, \$35.*

Mail orders accepted

MARK CROSS Fifth Avenue at 55th

*Plus 20% tax